Badauni approved of it, writing that ‘all kinds of instructive and useful topics’ were discussed in the Ibadat Khana’s collegial atmosphere. Too soon, however, the discussion had degenerated into dispute.

First, there was the question of precedence: it was to placate egos that the hall was separated into its four wings, each reserved for one category of discussant, with Akbar at their centre. Then, of course, there was the question not so much of having discussions as of winning arguments, and this was not so easily resolved. Badauni describes one particularly agitated night, when the ‘vein of the neck of the Ulama . . . swelled up, and a horrid noise and confusion ensued’. Annoyed, Akbar told Badauni to let him know, henceforth, if anyone spoke improperly in the hall; he would have them removed. ‘If I carried out this order,’ Badauni muttered under his breath, ‘most of the Ulama would have to leave.’ Akbar asked him to speak up, and laughed at his wit; but he wasn’t amused.[19]

Soon enough, it appears, the unruly theologians were evicted and the weekly discussions were closed, for Abul Fazl writes of them being resumed some three years later. It wasn’t, however, that Akbar had hit upon a scheme for ensuring calm and reasonable discussion; in fact, he seems to have decided to raise their pitch. In 1575, only Muslims of various stripes were invited into the Ibadat Khana. When the hall reopened in the autumn of 1578, it was flooded with every faith and philosophy in the land. ‘Sufi, philosopher, orator, jurist, Sunni, Shia, Brahman, Jati, Siura, Carbak [Charvaka,
sceptic], Nazarene, Jew, Sabi [Sabian], Zoroastrian, and others enjoyed exquisite pleasure,’ writes Abul Fazl cheerfully, as Akbar sat upon a ‘lofty pulpit’ listening to his guests, who ‘opened out [their secrets] without fear of hostile seekers after battle’.

Badauni paints a less rosy picture. It wasn’t debate that occurred in the Ibadat Khana, but war. ‘The learned men used to draw the sword of
the tongue on the battle-field of mutual contradiction and opposition,
and the antagonism of the sects reached such a pitch that they would call one another fools and heretics.’ Former friends became bitter foes in their desperation to impress the emperor, as, for example, Makhdum-ul-Mulk and Abdun Nabi, once joined in their persecution of Mahdawis, now hissing and clawing at each other aboard their sinking ship. Makhdum-ul-Mulk